Monophenomenalism

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Abstract

This paper formulates a philosophical position called monophenomenalism. Its starting point is that everything that exists is a phenomenon, and that the phenomenon is one. Unity here does not mean the numerical unity of a single object or the denial of distinctions between things and events. It indicates a refusal to introduce, as a starting explanatory principle, a second ground established independently of and external to the phenomenon.

The argument for the position begins from the fact that any claim, doubt, or proof available to us is formulated and assessed within experiencing. A claim about a ground independent of experiencing cannot be justified by moving to a standpoint wholly independent of experiencing. This argument, however, establishes a limit to justification; it does not prove that everything that exists is identical with experiencing or that independent reality is absent. Monophenomenalism is proposed as a philosophical position adopted as a starting point, not as a compulsory deductive conclusion.

The paper examines the relation of monophenomenalism to monism, phenomenalism, neutral monism, Advaita Vedānta, idealism, phenomenology, and radical constructivism. It identifies the position's putative distinctive features and the questions that require further investigation.

The Model of the Phenomenon is considered as one possible research tool within monophenomenalism. It does not serve as proof of the position, but makes it possible to analyze interpretations and implications, distinguish immediate conclusions from claims requiring additional premises, and test the logical consistency of arguments.

This is an exploratory study. Its aim is to formulate the position, mark the limits of its claims, define its relation to existing philosophical approaches, and outline a space for further inquiry.

Translation Note

This text is an English translation of the original Russian work, Монофеноменализм (Monophenomenalism). The original Russian version is available at: https://doi.org/10.5281/zenodo.23375020.

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1. Introduction

1.1. The Problem

Philosophy offers many ways of describing the relation between experiencing and what is regarded as a reality independent of it.

Materialism links the fundamental ground of reality to the material or physical. Dualist positions recognize principles that differ in nature. Idealist approaches assign different roles to mind, spirit, or the structure of cognition. Neutral monism treats the mental and the physical as derivatives of a nature that is itself neither exclusively mental nor exclusively physical. Phenomenology investigates the structure of experiencing and the ways in which objects are given. These traditions are heterogeneous and have their own arguments and internal distinctions.

Monophenomenalism does not aim to refute these approaches. Its task is to formulate a philosophical position in which everything that exists is considered one phenomenon, without first introducing a ground beyond it that has been established independently.

The questions of the external world, matter, the subject, consciousness, or another fundamental entity are considered here in terms of how these concepts are posited and justified. Any reasoning about them available to us takes place within experiencing. This fact alone, however, does not entail that the supposedly independent object does not exist. It points instead to a limitation in how its existence can be justified: we cannot justify it by moving to a standpoint wholly independent of experiencing.

The problem, therefore, is not to declare the external world an illusion or to prove that all independent reality is impossible. It is to ask whether the one phenomenon can be adopted as a starting philosophical position without introducing a separately established ground for its existence, and what implications follow from adopting it.

1.2. Research Question

Can a philosophical position be formulated in which everything that is is considered one phenomenon, while the external, the subject, and other supposed grounds are not introduced as independently established starting entities?

How does such a position differ from existing philosophical approaches, and what avenues for further inquiry does it open?

1.3. Starting Proposition

This paper proposes a philosophical position called monophenomenalism.

Its starting proposition is:

Everything that exists is a phenomenon. The phenomenon is one.

Here, “one” does not denote a single object among many objects. It denotes the absence of a separately established second ground in relation to which the phenomenon would be only one of two or more independently posited domains of existence.

Two related but non-identical aspects must be distinguished in this starting proposition. The first is ontological: everything that exists is considered one phenomenon. The second is methodological: no ground beyond the phenomenon that has been established independently is introduced as a starting premise. The methodological aspect is motivated by an argument about the limits of justification, but that argument does not deductively entail the ontological proposition that the phenomenon is one.

This proposition is adopted as a starting philosophical commitment. It is not derived by strict deduction from the fact that experiencing occurs, nor does it prove that the external world is absent. The argument offered in support of the position shows the limits of justifying claims about an independent ground, but does not by itself establish the truth of monophenomenalism.

Monophenomenalism does not claim that the existence of an independent ground has been proven, but neither does it claim to prove that such a ground is absolutely absent. It does not accept such a ground as a mandatory starting premise, and it treats the distinction between internal and external as a distinction that itself requires philosophical analysis.

In this paper, the term “monophenomenalism” is used to designate this particular position. The introduction of a new term is not itself taken as proof that the doctrine is historically or substantively novel. Any such novelty must be assessed by comparing its claims with existing approaches.

1.4. Aims and Scope

The paper has four aims.

First, to formulate the starting proposition of monophenomenalism and define what it does and does not claim.

Second, to show the grounds on which this position may be considered a philosophical commitment while also identifying the limits of the argument offered.

Third, to compare monophenomenalism with closely related philosophical approaches without reducing their differences to one general opposition.

Fourth, to show how monophenomenalism might be used in further research and how its own claims can be distinguished from interpretations obtained with the help of additional conceptual tools.

The paper does not claim to resolve exhaustively the problems of being, consciousness, causality, or cognition. It proposes a starting position and defines a range of questions that can be considered within it.

2. The Argument and the Limits of Its Proving Power

2.1. There Is Experiencing

Premise 1. There is experiencing.

Doubt, denial, thought, or a claim about something is given in experiencing. An attempt to deny the presence of experiencing itself occurs as experiencing.

For the purposes of this argument, experiencing is the starting point: it is impossible to formulate a denial of experiencing without relying on experiencing in the very act of denial.

This premise establishes the presence of experiencing as the starting point of reasoning. By itself, it does not claim that everything that exists is identical with experiencing, nor does it determine what should be regarded as existing beyond the experience available to us.

2.2. Claims Are Formulated Within Experiencing

Premise 2. Any claim about anything that is available to us is formulated within experiencing.

The external world, matter, the subject, consciousness, substance, or whatever is supposed to lie beyond experience becomes an object of reasoning through distinction and conceptualization.

One cannot formulate a claim about the external without engaging in an act of thought or speech. Nor can one offer a justification for the existence of an independent ground without using ways of distinguishing, concepts, and rules of reasoning.

This does not mean that the objects of reasoning are nothing but thoughts, or that they cannot exist independently of the person doing the reasoning. The claim being made is narrower: every claim about them available to us is formulated within experiencing.

The object of a claim must be distinguished from the claim itself. The fact that a claim about an object arises in experiencing does not mean that the object necessarily depends on that experiencing or is exhausted by it.

2.3. The Limits of Independent Verification

Premise 3. Any verification available to us takes place within experiencing.

Any observation, proof, doubt, or confirmation becomes available as part of experience. A claim that something exists independently of experiencing must likewise be formulated and justified within experiencing.

It is impossible to obtain justification by stepping outside all experiencing in order to compare experiencing with a standpoint wholly independent of it. Any procedure for making such a comparison that is available to us must itself be presented in experience.

A limited conclusion follows: the independence of a ground cannot be justified by appealing to a standpoint that would be wholly independent of experiencing.

This does not, however, rule out indirect justification. For example, the stability of observations, the consistency of results across different studies, the success of predictions, and the explanatory power of theories may be considered arguments for the existence of an external world. Such arguments do not require literally stepping outside experience; they are assessed within it.

The inaccessibility of a wholly independent standpoint is therefore not equivalent to the impossibility of any justification for realism. Monophenomenalism does not automatically refute arguments for the existence of an independent reality. It raises the question of the status of the ground that is supposed to be independent of the phenomenon.

2.4. What Follows from the Argument

The three premises establish that all reasoning available to us, and every justification of claims about what exists, takes place within experiencing. But they do not, by strict deduction alone, establish that everything that exists is identical with experiencing or that the phenomenon is metaphysically one.

Three propositions must be distinguished here.

First. Everything we can assert, verify, and justify is available to us within experiencing.

Second. The limitations of attempts to establish the independence of a supposed ground by appealing to a standpoint wholly independent of experiencing must be taken into account.

Third. Everything that exists is a phenomenon; the phenomenon is one.

The first two propositions express epistemic limitations. The third is the starting proposition of monophenomenalism.

The move from the first two propositions to the third is an additional philosophical choice, not a logical consequence of the premises.

The argument explains why the position can be adopted without first introducing an independent ground. It does not prove that the position is mandatory, nor does it rule out alternative philosophical solutions.

Monophenomenalism is thus adopted as a starting philosophical commitment, not as the result of a strict deductive proof or an empirical experiment.

2.5. Why the Proposition Is Substantive

The formula “everything is one phenomenon” does not mean that distinctions are absent from experience. Objects, events, thoughts, states, people, space, time, and other concepts are distinguished. These distinctions can be stable, consistent, and practically significant.

Unity means not the absence of distinctions within the phenomenon, but a refusal to treat the division between the phenomenon and an independently established ground beyond it as a starting ontological commitment.

The external world is not declared an illusion. The subject is not declared a nonexistent object. Matter is not declared a false representation. But none of these terms is automatically accepted as the name of an ultimate ground without which the phenomenon cannot be described.

The substantive commitment of monophenomenalism is that everything that exists is considered within a single phenomenon, while any supposed ground beyond it requires separate justification and is not introduced in advance.

A possible advantage of this commitment is methodological economy: inquiry begins without first postulating a second fundamental ground. Yet economy of premises does not by itself prove the position true. Its value depends on whether this approach clarifies philosophical questions and which explanatory tasks it leaves open.

This commitment can be challenged. It cannot be considered proven merely because all reasoning about reality takes place within experiencing.

3. Monophenomenalism

3.1. Definition

Monophenomenalism is the philosophical position that everything that exists is a phenomenon and that the phenomenon is one. It does not introduce a separately established ground beyond the phenomenon as a starting explanatory principle.

Unity should not be understood as a numerical claim about the number of objects. It does not mean that only one concrete object exists or that distinctions between objects, people, and events are absent.

In this paper, “phenomenon” is used not only to mean a particular event or an individual object of perception. The term denotes everything that exists, considered within the one phenomenon. It does not mean that objects exist only insofar as they are individually perceived. This usage is part of the starting position, not the result of a proof that derives everything that exists from an individual act of experiencing.

In the Model of the Phenomenon, this proposition is developed further through the concepts of experiencing, distinction, concept, and experience. This way of describing things is a separate conceptual tool and is not a necessary part of the definition of monophenomenalism.

3.2. What Is Claimed

Monophenomenalism comprises three related propositions.

First. Everything that exists is considered a phenomenon.

The position does not treat the phenomenon as one independently existing domain alongside another independently posited domain. Within monophenomenalism, no second ground is established in relation to which the phenomenon would be merely an effect, manifestation, or part.

Second. The phenomenon is one.

Here, “one” denotes not the numerical unity of an object, but the absence of a separately established second ground. This neither denies internal distinctions nor asserts that all objects are identical to one another.

Third. Specific descriptions of the phenomenon require additional grounds and arguments.

Questions concerning the external world, the subject, consciousness, matter, causality, and other supposed grounds can be investigated from within the position. The starting proposition itself, however, does not determine exactly how the relevant distinctions arise or what specific conclusions follow from them.

Monophenomenalism establishes a starting position, but it does not predetermine the interpretations that may emerge from further inquiry into it.

3.3. What Is Not Claimed

Monophenomenalism does not claim that:

- it has been proven that nothing exists beyond experiencing;
- the external world is illusory or has been refuted;
- individual objects, people, or events do not exist in the ordinary and practical sense;
- only the individual “I” or its subjective sensations exist;
- everything that exists is an individual or universal consciousness;
- the phenomenon is a single substance, matter, mind, or neutral nature;
- all questions about consciousness, free will, death, or cognition are automatically resolved by the starting proposition;
- adopting the position automatically entails every conclusion drawn with the help of the Model of the Phenomenon;
- individual experiencing necessarily continues after death or, conversely, has been proven to cease in a metaphysical sense.

The position limits the range of grounds accepted as starting points, but it does not replace a separate investigation of each question.

3.4. Status of the Position

Monophenomenalism is proposed as a philosophical position, not as a definitively established truth.

It can be adopted as a starting basis for inquiry, criticized, or rejected. To adopt it is to agree to consider everything that exists as one phenomenon and not to introduce a ground beyond it, established independently, as a mandatory starting premise.

Monophenomenalism is not a scientific theory in the usual sense, because in its present formulation it offers neither independent experimental predictions nor a procedure for empirical falsification. Its definitions, arguments, and implications can nonetheless be examined logically and conceptually.

The absence of independent experimental predictions does not mean that the position is immune to criticism. It can be assessed in terms of the clarity of its definitions, consistency, validity of its inferences, substantive precision, and ability to distinguish its own commitments from additional interpretations.

3.5. Limits on Claims of Novelty

The term “monophenomenalism” is used to designate the position formulated in this paper. The mere introduction of a new name does not establish that the position's content was entirely absent from the history of philosophy.

Monophenomenalism has points of contact with various forms of monism, phenomenalism, neutral monism, and nondual approaches. Its distinctiveness must therefore be assessed not by its name, but by the particular combination of its starting commitments, definitions, and modes of argument.

It should also be noted that the English term “mono-phenomenalism” appeared earlier in Fritz Heinemann’s article “Goethe’s Phenomenological Method” (Philosophy, vol. 9, no. 33, 1934, pp. 67–81, p. 73). There it denotes a methodological requirement to consider, as far as possible, a plurality of natural phenomena as a whole. This usage does not mean that the term refers to the same position formulated here, but it does mean that the term itself cannot be presented as having been introduced for the first time historically in this paper.

The aim of this paper is to clarify the content of the proposed position and make it available for critical comparison. No claim is made that the position is absolutely unprecedented in history or entirely original.

4. Relation to Existing Philosophical Approaches

Monophenomenalism is formulated against the background of existing philosophical positions. The distinctions set out below concern specific claims made by these approaches; they do not imply that the approaches are untenable in every respect.

This comparison is preliminary. Each of the traditions considered includes different versions, so a definitive assessment of similarities and differences requires examining particular authors and arguments.

4.1. Monism

Monism is a family of positions that assert unity in different senses. Depending on the version, what is taken to be one may be a single concrete object, a single fundamental ground, or a single category of being [1].

On a broad understanding of monism, monophenomenalism may be considered one of its variants.

Its distinctive feature lies in how unity is understood. Monophenomenalism does not propose replacing a plurality of grounds with a new substance, a single material element, or one fundamental principle. It takes “phenomenon” to designate everything that exists and does not posit a separate fundamental nature behind it.

Thus, monophenomenalism is not opposed to monism as a whole. Its putative difference is that unity is not explained by appeal to a separately established substance or fundamental ground.

4.2. Phenomenalism

Phenomenalism includes various positions in which physical objects are analyzed in terms of actual or possible sensations. For example, in John Stuart Mill’s account, ordinary objects are understood through

stable possibilities of sensory perception [2]. Sense-data theories, in turn, examine supposed immediate objects of perception and their relation to ordinary physical objects [3; 4].

Monophenomenalism does not claim that each object is a distinct sensation or a set of sensations. Nor does it propose reducing an object to experiencing as a different, more fundamental kind of being.

Object and sensation are treated as distinguishable within the one phenomenon. The question of exactly how they relate and how the experience of an object is structured requires separate analysis.

Monophenomenalism should therefore not automatically be identified with phenomenalism. It may nonetheless overlap with some versions of it, especially those that understand objects primarily through how they are given in experience. The precise distinction must be established with reference to a specific version of phenomenalism.

4.3. Neutral Monism

Neutral monism seeks to explain the mental and the physical in terms of a nature that is itself neither exclusively mental nor exclusively physical. Different versions allow for a plurality of basic neutral elements, so neutral monism should not be reduced without qualification to the thesis that there is a single neutral principle [5].

In some versions of neutral monism, experience or elements encountered in experience play a special role in describing fundamental reality [5; 10]. This makes the approach particularly important for comparison with monophenomenalism. A proximity to experience, however, does not mean that the two positions fully coincide.

Monophenomenalism does not propose a neutral nature underlying the mental and the physical. It does not attempt to derive consciousness and matter from a common third entity. Its starting commitment is to consider everything that exists as one phenomenon, without first introducing an independent ground beyond it.

The primary difference is that neutral monism usually offers a specific account of the nature of the fundamental ground, whereas monophenomenalism does not establish such a ground. This does not mean that neutral monism necessarily posits two independently existing domains. The question is what is taken to be fundamental and whether it is introduced as a separate explanatory nature.

4.4. Advaita Vedānta

In Śaṅkara’s account, Advaita Vedānta connects nonduality with Brahman as fundamental reality and regards Ātman as identical with Brahman. Consciousness plays a central role in this tradition, and recognition of nonduality is associated with liberation [6].

Monophenomenalism does not introduce Brahman, universal consciousness, or another fundamental nature as the ground of the phenomenon. Nor does it establish liberation as the goal of adopting the position.

The two approaches may resemble one another in rejecting the independent status of certain distinctions. Their starting commitments nevertheless differ: Advaita Vedānta has its own metaphysical, epistemological, and practical claims, which do not follow from the definition of monophenomenalism.

Monophenomenalism is therefore not simply Advaita under a different name, nor is it presented in this paper as a refutation of Advaita. A more detailed comparison would require analyzing specific claims made by both positions.

4.5. Idealism

Idealism encompasses various positions. Some take mind or spirit to be the fundamental basis of reality; others emphasize the dependence of knowable reality on structures of thought and cognition [7].

Monophenomenalism does not declare mind or spirit to be the ground of the one phenomenon. It does not derive everything that exists from thought, nor does it claim that the world is created by an individual consciousness.

Its starting position is not that mind is primary and matter secondary, but that no independently established ground beyond the phenomenon is introduced as a starting principle.

Monophenomenalism may overlap with some forms of idealism on the question of the limits of justifying claims about the external. This similarity does not establish full agreement: the precise difference requires comparison with specific idealist theories, not idealism as a whole.

4.6. Phenomenology

Phenomenology investigates the structure of experiencing and the ways in which objects are given in consciousness. For Husserl in particular, intentionality—the directedness of experiencing toward an object—plays an essential role. Phenomenological approaches differ in how they understand the relation between experiencing, subjectivity, and an object independent of it [8].

Monophenomenalism offers a different starting way of describing intentional directedness. It can be considered not as a fundamental relation between two grounds posited in advance as independent, but as a distinction within the one phenomenon.

This does not mean that phenomenology itself asserts the existence of two independent substances. The difference lies in the starting questions and commitments: phenomenology investigates the structure of givenness and experiencing, whereas monophenomenalism adopts the one phenomenon as its starting philosophical position.

Monophenomenalism may use phenomenological descriptions, but it does not follow that phenomenology automatically leads to its starting proposition.

4.7. Radical Constructivism

Radical constructivism, associated with Ernst von Glasersfeld, emphasizes the constructive character of knowledge and considers cognitive schemes in terms of their viability in experience, rather than as simple copies of an independently given reality [9].

Monophenomenalism does not claim that cognition creates reality. Its starting position concerns the unity of the phenomenon, not the production of the world by a knowing subject.

Monophenomenalism treats distinctions as possible ways of structuring experience, but this should not automatically be identified with the construction of knowledge in the sense intended by radical constructivism.

What these approaches may share is an attention to the limits of cognition. The question of the structure of knowledge, however, is not identical to the question of what is taken to be the starting ground of what exists.

4.8. The General Distinction and the Open Question of Classification

Monophenomenalism does not introduce a separately established fundamental ground beyond the phenomenon. This is its central commitment.

It does not rule out investigating the external world, the subject, consciousness, causality, or matter. It proposes considering these questions from within the adopted position, without establishing in advance an independent entity as the ultimate ground of the phenomenon.

Under a broad definition of monism, monophenomenalism may be classified as one of its variants. Its independence as a position therefore cannot be justified simply by contrasting it with all existing schools.

Its putative specificity lies in the combination of two claims: adopting the one phenomenon as a starting philosophical position and refusing to introduce an independently established ground beyond it.

Whether this combination is sufficient to distinguish an independent school of thought remains an open question for further philosophical discussion.

5. Examples of Application

The following examples show how monophenomenalism may be applied to the investigation of various questions. They are not exhaustive, and they are not automatically proven implications of the starting position. Where the Model of the Phenomenon is used, the conclusions should be treated as interpretations within that model.

5.1. The External World

Monophenomenalism does not introduce the external world as a ground of the phenomenon established independently.

The idea of an external world is present within the phenomenon as a concept through which experience is structured. This does not mean that the external world is declared an illusion or that its absence has been proven.

The distinction between internal and external requires analysis. Any claim about the external world is formulated within experiencing; it does not follow, however, that the object of the claim cannot exist independently of a particular act of experiencing or of the knowing subject.

Monophenomenalism proposes that the independence of the external world should not be accepted as an ultimate starting explanatory ground without separate justification. It does not cancel the investigation of the external world or replace scientific or philosophical arguments for realism.

5.2. The Subject

Within the Model of the Phenomenon, the subject can be considered through the distinctions between “I” and “world,” self and other, and internal and external.

In this analysis, the “I” need not function as a separate fundamental entity that owns experience and serves as its independent source. It is considered a distinction through which experience is structured as having a center, a boundary, or a bearer.

This does not deny the existence of people, their bodies, actions, memories, individual characteristics, or practical responsibility. It means that the subject is not introduced in advance as an independent fundamental ground.

This understanding of the subject is an example of applying the model and requires analysis of additional claims about distinction and structuring. Monophenomenalism itself does not prove that the familiar concept of the subject is mistaken or unnecessary in all its senses.

5.3. Death

Death is usually understood as the cessation of life and the end of individual existence. Within the Model of the Phenomenon, it can be investigated as a concept of an end, a loss, or the cessation of a particular form of life that structures experience.

The question of the end of the phenomenon as a whole must be distinguished from the question of the cessation of a particular organism’s life and of individual experiencing. The fact that the concept of an end is given within the phenomenon does not by itself mean that individual experience continues after death.

The model makes it possible to investigate how the distinction between life and death structures experience, but it does not by itself prove either the posthumous continuation of individual experiencing or its impossibility.

Therefore, the proposition “death is not the end of the phenomenon,” which appears in the Model of the Phenomenon, should be understood in this paper as an interpretive proposal for inquiry, not as an immediate consequence of the definition of monophenomenalism.

5.4. Causality and Cognition

Monophenomenalism makes it possible to ask whether causality should be accepted as a fundamental structure of what exists or treated as a way of describing relations between events.

The starting proposition of monophenomenalism does not, however, by itself entail that causal relations do not exist. Such a conclusion requires additional arguments and clarification of what is meant by causality.

Likewise, the claim that knowledge available to us is formulated within experiencing does not mean that scientific theories are arbitrary or that all explanations are equally valid. Scientific methods make it possible

to test observations, establish regularities, compare models, and assess predictions. Monophenomenalism does not set these procedures aside.

It proposes a separate investigation of the status of concepts used to describe reality, and cautions against confusing the limits of a method of justification with proof that the thing being discussed does not exist.

6. Objections and Replies

6.1. Is This Solipsism?

No, if solipsism is understood as the position that only the individual “I” or only its experiences exist.

Monophenomenalism does not take the individual “I” as the fundamental ground from which the existence of the world is derived. The distinctions between “I” and “world,” and between “mine” and “other,” are treated as questions to be investigated within the one phenomenon.

It does not follow, however, that monophenomenalism proves the existence of other minds. Nor does it prove their absence. The position offers a different starting point for posing the question, one that does not assume a separate fundamental subject as a necessary ground.

6.2. Is This an Unfalsifiable Position?

In its proposed formulation, monophenomenalism is not a scientific theory built on independent experimental predictions. Ordinary empirical falsification therefore cannot be applied to it directly in the same way as it is applied to specific scientific hypotheses.

The absence of independent experimental predictions does not, however, make criticism impossible.

Definitions can be examined, contradictions identified, inferences assessed for validity, unstated premises exposed, and a substantive distinction between the position and its alternatives required.

Moreover, specific implications proposed within monophenomenalism may have empirical content. If so, they must be assessed using appropriate methods of testing.

Monophenomenalism thus allows logical, conceptual, and comparative criticism, even though its starting proposition is not an ordinary experimental hypothesis.

6.3. How Does Monophenomenalism Differ from Advaita?

Monophenomenalism does not accept Brahman or universal consciousness as a necessary ground, and it does not establish liberation as the goal of adopting the position.

This difference does not mean that monophenomenalism refutes the claims of Advaita Vedānta or that the two approaches have nothing in common. It concerns their specific starting commitments.

A more detailed comparison would require examining Advaita Vedānta’s arguments concerning Brahman, Ātman, knowledge, and liberation and comparing them with the definition of monophenomenalism. The present paper does not undertake such a comprehensive comparison.

6.4. What Does Monophenomenalism Contribute to Science?

Monophenomenalism does not replace the scientific method, establish new laws of physics, or offer independent experimental predictions.

Its possible role is philosophical and methodological. It allows the status of concepts used in scientific description—particularly causality, objectivity, observation, the subject, and cognition—to be investigated without assuming in advance that they are fundamental.

This does not mean that causality, objectivity, or scientific knowledge are declared illusions. Nor should it be assumed that scientific theories become arbitrary concepts. Specific conclusions about science require independent arguments and, where appropriate, reference to empirical data.

6.5. Is It a Tautology?

The formula “everything is a phenomenon” depends on the meaning assigned to the word “phenomenon.” If the term is defined in advance as everything that exists, this part of the formula may look like a definition rather than an independent conclusion.

Within monophenomenalism, however, the formula is used for more than simply renaming what exists. It expresses a refusal to set the phenomenon in opposition, from the outset, to a separately established ground that is supposed to exist independently of it.

The substantive meaning of the position lies in adopting the one phenomenon without first introducing a second fundamental ground. This does not remove the need to justify the position itself, but it clarifies what is open to debate in it.

Monophenomenalism therefore cannot be considered proven merely on the basis of the term’s definition. Its substantive commitment is not exhausted by the verbal formula: it consists in a specific refusal to make the initial division between the phenomenon and an independently established ground.

6.6. Why Is the Phenomenon One?

The unity of the phenomenon is the starting proposition of monophenomenalism, not a conclusion derived from the preceding premises.

“One” does not mean the numerical unity of an object. The point is not to deny distinctions, but to refuse to treat the phenomenon as one independently established domain of existence alongside another independently established domain.

The argument about the limits of justification explains why the position can be adopted without first introducing an independent ground. But this argument does not prove the unity of the phenomenon and does not rule out alternative philosophical positions.

Thus, this paper does not offer a proof of the proposition “the phenomenon is one” that every possible researcher would be obliged to accept. Instead, it proposes the proposition as a starting philosophical commitment and opens the question of its substantive advantages over alternatives.

6.7. Is the Position Itself an Unjustified Ontological Claim?

A possible objection is that the phrase “everything that exists” already presupposes a particular understanding of existence, and that the claim about the unity of the phenomenon may itself be read as a claim about the structure of reality.

This objection touches on an important feature of the position. Monophenomenalism is not a neutral description that carries no philosophical commitments. Its starting proposition has ontological significance: everything that exists is considered one phenomenon.

At the same time, an ontological commitment must be distinguished from a methodological decision. The former consists in adopting the one phenomenon as a description of everything that exists. The latter consists in refusing to introduce an independently established ground as a starting premise for inquiry. These claims are related but not identical: the methodological decision does not by itself prove the ontological thesis.

Monophenomenalism does not claim that the absence of an independently established ground has been proven for every possible philosophy. It proposes not to introduce such a ground as a starting premise, and to consider questions about it within the one phenomenon.

Monophenomenalism should therefore be understood not as proof that all independent reality is absent, but as a philosophical commitment of a particular kind. This commitment can be challenged, including by a realist who considers the existence of an independent world to be well justified.

Such an objection cannot be answered merely by pointing to the limits of experiencing. It calls for further comparison of the advantages and costs of alternative starting positions.

6.8. Who Adopts Monophenomenalism?

The position is adopted by a researcher who agrees to consider everything that exists as one phenomenon and not to introduce an independently established ground beyond it as a starting explanatory principle.

Within the position itself, the act of adopting it may be described as a distinction within the phenomenon. This does not change the fact that people formulate, discuss, accept, or reject philosophical positions.

Monophenomenalism does not require introducing the subject as an independent fundamental ground, but it does not prohibit using the concept of the subject in ordinary, practical, or scholarly language.

7. Relation to the Model of the Phenomenon

7.1. Position and Tool

Monophenomenalism establishes a starting philosophical position: everything that exists is a phenomenon; the phenomenon is one.

The Model of the Phenomenon is one possible research tool within this position. Its five theses describe the phenomenon through experiencing, distinction, concept, and experience.

The position and the model are related, but they are not identical. Monophenomenalism does not require adopting this particular model. Other researchers may work within the same position while using different methods of description and analysis.

The model does not prove monophenomenalism and is not a ground for its truth. It serves as a tool for investigating the implications of the adopted position and for identifying shifts in meaning and inconsistencies in reasoning.

7.2. Distinguishing Terms and Levels of Description

In monophenomenalism, the term “phenomenon” denotes everything that exists, considered within a unified philosophical position.

In the Model of the Phenomenon, the starting formula “everything is one phenomenon” is developed further: the phenomenon is defined through sensory experiencing, while experience is the phenomenon structured through concepts. In the model, experiencing, distinction, concept, and experience function as different ways of conceptually describing the one phenomenon [12].

These formulations should not automatically be treated as identical in meaning. The starting proposition of monophenomenalism does not require accepting precisely the definitions of experiencing, distinction, concept, and experience specified in the model.

When a researcher moves from the starting proposition of monophenomenalism to the model’s specific theses, they adopt additional working definitions. Implications that depend on those definitions must be distinguished from what the position itself directly commits one to.

Thus, the compatibility of particular claims in the model with monophenomenalism does not mean that they follow logically from it. Every such transition requires independent analysis.

7.3. What Exactly Does the Model Test?

The model can be used to examine the logic of implications. This examination involves several questions.

First. Does the claim follow from the starting position?

It must be established whether a conclusion follows directly from monophenomenalism or requires additional propositions from the model.

Second. Does the meaning of the terms remain stable?

One must check whether one meaning of a word is substituted for another during the argument. For example, the cessation of an individual life is not identical to the proven cessation of the phenomenon as a whole.

Third. Does a contradiction arise?

It must be checked whether individual claims are compatible when the same definitions are applied throughout.

Fourth. Is an additional ground being introduced?

One must check whether an independent subject is introduced without justification as the source of experience, or an external entity as the ultimate ground of the phenomenon.

Fifth. Is an interpretation being presented as a necessary conclusion?

If a proposition depends on additional premises, this must be stated explicitly.

Such an examination is not automatically a formal proof. Its purpose is to make the reasoning transparent and allow readers to assess for themselves how well the transitions between theses are justified.

7.4. The Statuses of Implications

For investigating implications, it is useful to distinguish four statuses.

1. Follows directly from the position. The conclusion follows from the starting proposition of monophenomenalism without recourse to additional theses of the model.

2. Follows within the model. The conclusion follows when monophenomenalism and the additional propositions of the Model of the Phenomenon are accepted.

3. Compatible with the position but does not follow from it. The claim may be accepted within monophenomenalism, but requires independent justification.

4. Contradicts the position or requires clarification. The conclusion is incompatible with the adopted definitions or relies on an unstated premise.

These statuses do not replace a full logical analysis. They help distinguish monophenomenalism itself from interpretations developed in the course of research.

The Model of the Phenomenon is a conceptual framework, not a formalized logical system with an exhaustive set of inference rules. It can be used to test internal consistency and identify shifts in meaning, but its use should not automatically be equated with formal proof.

7.5. Examples of Applying the Classification

Several claims from the Model of the Phenomenon can be considered to illustrate the proposed method of analysis.

Claim: “The ‘I’ is a distinction, not that which distinguishes.”

This proposition does not follow directly from the definition of monophenomenalism. It depends on additional definitions of the subject, distinction, and concept within the Model of the Phenomenon. It should therefore be treated as a claim within the model that requires separate analysis.

Claim: “Death is not the end of the phenomenon.”

This claim requires clarification of the meaning of “phenomenon.” If the point is that the concept of an end arises within the phenomenon, this does not prove that individual experiencing continues after death. If the claim is that such experiencing does continue, an independent argument is required. With respect to individual post-mortem experience, therefore, the claim follows neither from monophenomenalism nor automatically from the model itself.

Claim: “There is no necessity in cause and effect.”

The starting proposition of monophenomenalism does not entail that causal relations do not exist. This conclusion depends on additional claims about time, change, sequence, and the conceptual structuring of experience. It should be analyzed within the model, with separate attention to whether causality itself is being denied or only its status as an independently existing fundamental ground.

Claim: “Other minds are distinctions within one phenomenon.”

This claim does not prove either the existence or the absence of other minds. It sets out a way of interpreting the distinctions between “I” and “other” within the model. Stronger conclusions about the nature of consciousness or the status of other people would require additional arguments.

These examples show the practical value of classifying implications: it prevents the starting philosophical proposition from being turned into a universal proof of every conclusion that might be associated with it.

7.6. Independence from the Model

Monophenomenalism can be adopted independently of the Model of the Phenomenon. The position does not require all its proponents to accept experiencing, distinction, concept, and experience exactly as they are defined in the model.

If a researcher does use this model, its theses and definitions become working premises for the analysis. The conclusions drawn must be consistent with these premises or explicitly state where they extend beyond them.

Thus, monophenomenalism defines the starting position, while the Model of the Phenomenon offers one possible tool for investigating it and checking the logical consistency of its implications.

See Dudnikov, *Model of the Phenomenon*, Working Draft, Version 2 [12].

8. Conclusion

This paper has proposed monophenomenalism, a philosophical position according to which everything that exists is a phenomenon, and the phenomenon is one.

Unity here does not mean that there is one object instead of many. It denotes a starting commitment to consider everything that exists as one phenomenon and not to introduce an independently established ground beyond it as a prior explanatory premise.

The argument for the position begins with the existence of experiencing, the fact that any claims available to us are formulated within experiencing, and the fact that a justification for an independent ground cannot be obtained by moving to a standpoint wholly independent of experiencing.

These points establish a limit to justification, but they do not derive monophenomenalism by strict deduction. They do not prove that the external world or any independent reality is absent. Monophenomenalism is adopted as a starting philosophical position that may be challenged, rejected, or accepted for further inquiry.

A possible advantage of the position is that inquiry begins without first postulating a second fundamental ground. The substantive value of this approach, however, must be assessed not only in terms of economy of premises, but also by how well it clarifies philosophical questions and what difficulties it leaves unresolved.

The comparison with monism, phenomenalism, neutral monism, Advaita Vedānta, idealism, phenomenology, and radical constructivism reveals points of similarity and putative differences. Yet monophenomenalism's distinctiveness is not established merely by introducing a new term. It requires further analysis of specific claims, arguments, and alternative explanations.

The Model of the Phenomenon is one tool for inquiry within monophenomenalism. It does not prove the starting position, but it allows possible implications to be examined, logical transitions to be checked, and conclusions directly associated with the starting proposition to be distinguished from interpretations that depend on additional definitions.

The paper does not claim to provide a final solution to questions of being, consciousness, the subject, causality, or cognition. Its aim is to formulate the position, define the limits of its claims, and identify a space for further inquiry.

Monophenomenalism is proposed not as a final truth, but as a philosophical position open to substantive criticism. Its further development requires clarifying the concept of unity, comparing it in greater detail with existing approaches, and systematically checking conclusions reached through different research models.

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